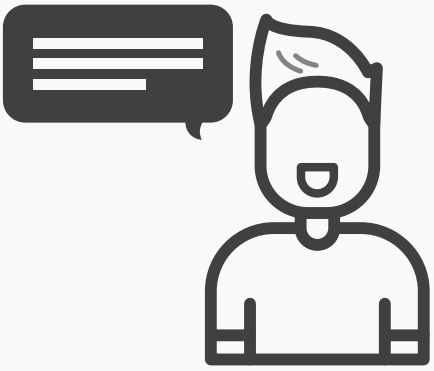

How to Get More Honest Feedback in User Tests

User testing is not as simple as it might seem. That's because users might not give us the honest feedback that we need for various reasons. For instance, they might not want to hurt your feelings. Or they might think you're testing them rather than the design, and thus try to avoid 'committing' errors.

Here's what you can do before, during and after a test to get more honest feedback from users.

Before a User Test

Let users feel comfortable giving negative feedback. Some things you can say include:

> *Hi! I'm here today because I'm hired by [company] to test their design. Since I'm not related to [company] at all, you don't have to worry about hurting my feelings! Feel free to give feedback, good or bad, so that we can learn and improve the design.*

> *I'm here today to test a product that my colleague has created. Don't worry, I won't feel hurt if you say something negative about the design. In fact, I love hearing negative feedback because it lets me improve my colleague's design!*

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Let them know that you're here to test the design and not them. You can say:

> *Today, we're not here to test you. We're here to test the design. We know this design might have some issues, and we need your help to identify those issues.*

Politely request that they think out loud:

> *May I request that you think out loud: this means that you should vocalize everything that you're thinking. For example, when you click a button, you can say something like "I want to click this button because I think that's how I purchase this item." Or, when you're looking for something on a page, say something like "I'm trying to find the shoe category in this website."*

During the User Test

Remind the user to think out loud if they fall silent. You can say:

> *What are you thinking right now?*
>
> *Can you explain what you're doing right now?*
>
> *Could you please think out loud, so I can follow what you're doing?*

Note down any strange behaviors or questions that you've formed in your head while observing your user. Ask them either at the end of the task or at the end of the entire test session.

After the User Test

If you've written down notes, ask them about these at the end of the test.

Ask them for more feedback:

> *How would you improve this product if you could?*
>
> *What are some parts of the product that you liked?*
>
> *What are some parts of the product that you wish were different?*
>
> *Do you have any feedback or ideas on the product? They can be totally unrelated from our test session.*

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